agreed with the plan, realised we would need some food and ran to fetch a packet of Marie biscuits from the kitchen. My mother was not around, so there was no opportunity to say goodbye, and the two of us headed for the road that led out of town. After a couple of kilometres, we were joined by a Labrador. Neither of us knew the dog, but we were pleased to have company, so we continued our great trek.

'Where are you two going?'

The firm voice belonged to a policeman. We had been stopped.

'I'm going home to my mom,' said Stof, his courage evaporating, his voice faltering.

That was that, the end of our adventure. The two of us were bundled into the back of a van and taken to the police station, which was still exciting but we were starting to sense that the saga would not end well.

'We need to telephone your parents,' said the policeman.

'It is Warmbaths 2666,' I replied, pleased I could recite our number.

My mother came to collect us, and it is fair to say our parents made it abundantly clear to their respective sons that impromptu 10-kilometre walks were not to be tolerated in the future.

Chris Swanepoel has, like me, chosen to pursue a career in sport, becoming a professional golfer. He turned pro in 2004, and has won four tournaments on the Sunshine Tour, displaying all the energy, courage and determination that we admired in him when we were youngsters.

'So, Chris, what's the plan?'

It's 2001, we are 17 years old and, now at school in Pretoria, I am planning to spend the weekend back home in Warmbaths. Chris has recently been given a scooter by his father, as a reward for good marks at school, and it's difficult to imagine more fun than using the bikes to chase rabbits on the golf course.

'Well, Hannes van Staden and Jacques van Zyl are around,' he replies. 'Shall we take the bikes out?'